



Koh-i-noor diamond

△ **Replica of the Koh-i-noor** (centre) in its original cut and setting

The Koh-i-noor (“Mountain of Light”) diamond, like many famous gems, had a turbulent history. Mined in southern India, the stone was initially referred to in 1526 in the memoirs of Babur, the first Mogul king of India. It was a spoil of war, and it continued to change hands between kings over the course of several centuries, which may go some way towards explaining its reputation for being cursed, as whoever owned the huge diamond was a target for attack.

By the time five-year-old Duleep Singh came to power in 1843 as the last ruler of the Punjab and Sikh Empire, the diamond belonged to him, as the previous four maharajas had been assassinated while in possession of the stone. Just a few years later, the British dismantled Singh’s kingdom, and the Koh-i-noor transferred to British



Queen Elizabeth the Queen Mother, wearing the Koh-i-noor in a simple version of her crown

ownership as part of the treaty that incorporated the Punjab into the British Empire. Presented to Queen Victoria in London in 1850, the diamond was apparently accompanied by a curse that read: “He who owns this diamond will own the world, but will also know all its misfortunes. Only God or Woman can wear it with impunity”.

Far more controversial than the supposed curse was the criticism that the 186-carat gem looked dull due to poor cutting. Prince Albert decided to have the diamond recut in 1852, drastically reducing its size to 105.6 carats but eliminating several flaws in the process and creating an oval brilliant cut. Since then, the recut Koh-i-noor has been set in four different crowns, each worn by British queens, including Queen Alexandra, Queen Mary, and Queen Elizabeth the Queen Mother.



Koh-i-noor diamond (centre) in Queen Elizabeth the Queen Mother’s crown

Only God or Woman can wear it with impunity...

Curse said to have accompanied the Koh-i-noor

Key dates

1100–2015

